protection of Muslims but encouraged a robust condemnation of non-Muslim social practices. Akbar, meanwhile, was encouraging the entry of Persian Shia and Hindu Rajput noblemen into the Mughal aristocracy as part of his long-term plan to reduce the worrying influence of the large and fractious Turani clan, and was also marrying Hindu women. In this climate of social churn, the Chishtis of Hindustan were found to be a great deal more accommodating. They maintained a greater ascetic distance from kingship and flirted more openly with the idea of a religious cauldron, an amalgamation of various ideals and, in its more extreme variant, maintained that the world was a manifestation of ishq, love, above and beyond any religious limitations. ‘There is no precedence of one religion over the other’, they wrote, ‘after you experience the limitlessness of unbounded Beauty you can see His Grace present both in a kafir and a Muslim.’

In the harem at Agra, meanwhile, there was a flurry of further additions. A daughter, Khanum Sultan, was born to Akbar and then in 1570, a second prince, Murad. In November 1570, Rao Kalyanmal of Bikaner and his heir, Kuar Rai Singh, accepted Mughal overlordship and were brought into the Mughal fold. Rao Kalyanmal then offered a daughter and two nieces, Raj Kanwar and Bhanumati, in marriage to Akbar. At the same time Har Raj of Jaisalmer also submitted to Akbar and offered a daughter, Rajkumari Nathi Bai, as a wife for the Padshah while his son, Kuar Sultan Singh, was accepted as a nobleman at the Mughal court.

When the Rajput brides entered the Mughal harem they brought with them their holy fires and their sparkling language, their busy gods, and their swaying clothes. For Akbar did not require these women to convert to Islam and they were allowed to fully participate in their Hindu rituals as they had in their own homes. And yet, in an astounding sleight of hand, these women would disappear completely from the Mughal records, smoothed into impossible standards of purity and chastity, all individuality removed. So very rigorous would this vigilance be that there is only one record that clearly states that the mother of the much longed-for Mughal heir, Salim, was indeed Harkha Bai Kachhwaha. For these women, there would be no intimate accounts of labours arrested by plain-faced midwives or compassionate recordings of a young girl’s mixed feelings towards her determined groom. The name of Prince Murad’s mother was not noted and the celebrations following births were negligently narrated, formal and bloodless. The purdah, which had been cursory in the case of the Timurid